

Whose Side Are We On?

*Choosing Allegiance to the
Commander of the Lord's Army*



Joshua 5:13-15



July 4, 2026 — America's 250th Anniversary

A Quarter Millennium of American Freedom



Parades, fireworks, and
cookouts across America



250 years of independence —
a remarkable experiment in liberty



Celebrating First Amendment freedoms:
Sabbath, worship, and gospel proclamation



*These are freedoms we
shouldn't take for granted.*

But We Are Also Deeply Divided



Divided by race, gender, education, and geography



Political rhetoric: “If you’re not for us, you’re against us”



Friendships ended.
Families torn apart.



Even at the cookout,
things get tense.

Christians Are Caught in the Crossfire



Christians can be just as divided as everyone else.



Social media: name-calling, propaganda, misinformation.



Too often, our allegiance to a political party supersedes our allegiance to Christ.

“ By this everyone will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another. ”

— JOHN 13:35

Have We Made Jesus a Political Ally?



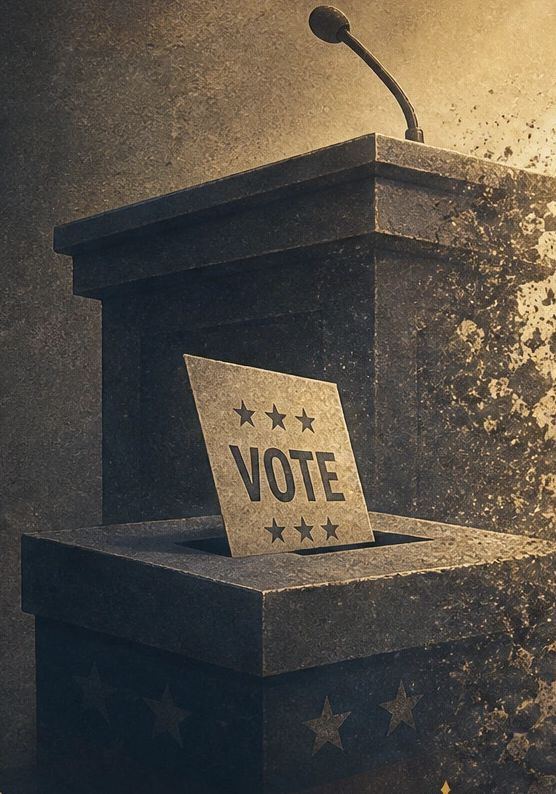
Turning political icons into idols



Treating political leaders as saviors



Assuming Jesus aligns with a specific political party



“Judging by the rhetoric, you might think Jesus’ name is on the ballot.”

The Text That Changes Everything

“Once when Joshua was by Jericho, he looked up and saw a man standing before him with a drawn sword in his hand. Joshua went to him and said, ‘Are you one of us or one of our adversaries?’ He replied, ‘Neither; but as commander of the army of the Lord I have now come.’ And Joshua fell on his face to the earth and worshiped... ‘Remove the sandals from your feet, for the place where you stand is holy.’”

— Joshua 5:13-15 —

Joshua Faces the Walls of Jericho



Israel has crossed the Jordan —
but the hardest challenge is ahead



Jericho: massive, fortified, terrifying —
walls they had never seen before



Joshua slips away at night
to survey the city alone



Fear still lingers
in the deeper regions of his heart



A Man Armed for War



A figure appears in the darkness —
sword already drawn



Joshua's military instinct:
"Are you for us or for our enemies?"



The question assumes a binary:
friend or foe, ally or adversary



This is the natural logic of a general
assessing a stranger on a battlefield



The Most Surprising Word in Scripture



“Neither. But as commander of the army of the Lord I have now come.”



He rejects the premise of the question entirely



He is not a combatant to be recruited —
He is the Commander over Joshua



Joshua falls on his face and worships —
recognizing divine authority



The Commander Is Christ



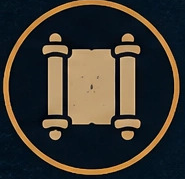
**This is not just an angel —
Joshua's worship is accepted**
(contrast: Rev. 19:10)



John 1:1 —
*"In the beginning was the Word...
and the Word was God."*



**The story of Jesus did not begin
in a manger — He is the eternal Creator**



Daniel 8:11
uses the same title for the pre-incarnate Christ



SDA Theology:
Ellen White identifies this as Christ



Jesus Is Not on Your Side



Jesus is not on your side.
He is also not on your enemy's side.



The sovereign God of the universe
is far above any notion of sides we create.



We reduce Jesus to a trump card or
a weapon for our quarrels.



The real question is not:
“Is God on my side?” but

but
**Am I on
God's side?**

An Enormous Chasm of Difference



Believing God is on your side

→ You are in control; God is your ally



Choosing to be on God's side

→ God is in command; you are the servant



Joshua thought he was the commander of the Lord's army



Jesus corrected him:

"There is only one Commander — and it isn't you."



The Call to Surrender



*“Remove the sandals from your feet,
for the place where you stand is holy.”*



Bare feet on rough terrain:
no escape, no fallback plan



This is total surrender —
no options kept open



Parallel to Moses at the burning bush
(Exodus 3:5)



SDA Sanctuary Theology:
God's presence sanctifies space
and demands reverence



What Does It Mean to Be on God's Side?



673 million people are starving globally



36 million Americans live in poverty



Racism, broken homes, abuse of power — these are real evils



Christians are called to holy anger and real action



Not partisan bickering — but surrender-driven service

“Whoever wants to become great among you must be your servant.”

MATTHEW 20:26

He Is Coming Back



Jesus cares about every tear,
every injustice, every human life.



“His eye is on the sparrow —
and His eye is on every human life.”



Jesus already has a sword in His hand.



On a day coming very soon,
He will break through the clouds of heaven.



He will lead the angel armies to end
sin, evil, and suffering once and forevermore.

The Strongest Position in the Universe



The most powerful place you can be in this universe is **at the feet of Jesus**.



The strongest thing we can do in this life is **surrender at the foot of the cross**.



While our nation fights for the soul of America — **surrender your soul** to Jesus Christ.



Pledge your life to following the **Commander of the Lord's Army**.



How the World Will Know

- ✦ This church will not be known by how sure we are that we're right.
- ✦ We will be known by how we treat our neighbors whom we're convinced are wrong.
- ✦ *“By this everyone will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another.”*
— John 13:35
- ✦ Choose to be different in a divided world.



Lord, We Choose Your Side



PRAYER:

*Lord Jesus, You are the Commander of the Lord's Army.
Today we recognize that You are not on our side —
but we choose to be on Yours.*

*Give us the courage to follow You in difficult circumstances.
Give us the strength to surrender to You right now,
so that we can show Your love to our neighbors.
In Your precious and holy name, Amen.*



Will you choose today to be on His side?